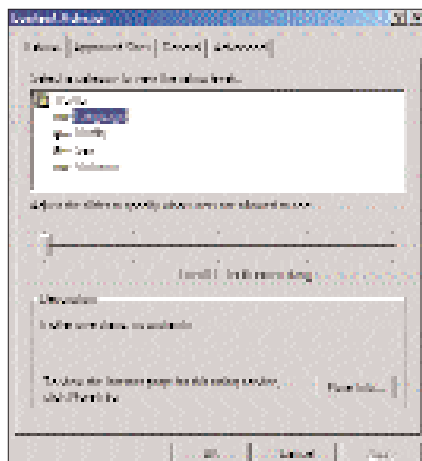




Content filtering in IE 6

contains a host of other links on various topics. However, if you feel cheated by the fact that their viewing space has been eaten up, you can easily do away with the side tab bar by customising the interface.

Another feature that enhances a browser's usability is if a search engine is embedded into the browser itself. All five browsers in this category allow you to choose your favourite search engine as a default and the results are displayed within the browser itself. For instance, NeoPlanet uses the Lycos search bot to search for relevant links but there is little you can do to customise it. IE displays the result in the side bar by using MSN by default, whereas Netscape uses its own Netscape.com engine to perform such searches. However, in both cases you can choose to use other engines such as Google or Yahoo!.

Browsers tend to occupy quite a bit of your hard disk space, especially if they bundle a lot of small utilities. Netscape and Internet Explorer are space hoggers as they come bundled with a lot of extras, whereas Mozilla occupies just 20 MB of space. Though NeoPlanet takes only 9 MB to install, it requires Internet Explorer to be already installed on your machine.

As far as the load-up time is concerned, NeoPlanet was the slowest of the lot, while Internet Explorer was the fastest. Netscape 6.1 surprised us by loading up quite fast; its previous version had an extremely slow load-up time and was also extremely resource hungry. With this version Netscape seems to have ironed out this problem by using the same technology that Internet Explorer uses. The quick load feature loads up some of the frequently used Netscape files into the memory as soon as the machine starts. Although this adds around 3 to 6 seconds to your sys-

tem startup time, it makes opening up a browser window almost as fast as Internet Explorer. Internet Explorer loads almost all of its files as soon as your Windows Explorer loads during boot-up.

The goodies

What better news for a cyber junkie than a browser that comes with a host of utilities such as instant messaging, an e-mail client and other goodies but at the same time doesn't compromise on surfing speed?

The new version of Internet Explorer not only loads up as fast as its previous version, but also bundles a host of new features, which were missing in the other browsers. One such feature, image resizing, allows you to resize and fit a large image in your browser window without having to scroll down your page. An automatic image bar pops up whenever you move your mouse over an image, allowing you to save, print or e-mail the image with a click rather than using the cumbersome right-click menu.

In comparison to this, Netscape 6.1 comes with multiple profiles, which allows several people to use the same browser without having to share favourites and other details such as mails and cache. It is also the only browser that provides the option of remembering your passwords and login names while preventing others from misusing this data. Using its password manager program, you can choose



Image resizing in IE6

whether or not to let other users see your password.

NeoPlanet (which also has the multiple profiles option) and Internet Explorer also provide the option for remembering your password and login names, but you cannot prevent them from being viewed by others.

Instant messaging: All five browsers in this category incorporate an instant messenger.

iBench Explained

To test a Web browser's HTML rendering and loading performance, we used ZD's iBench benchmark HTML load-up test. We ran this test on a 100 Mbps LAN connection with one server and one client, hence eliminating any other bottlenecks that could slow down the test. This test automatically loads up over 120 HTML pages within a short span of time. Even the slowest of the browsers finished the test well within 110 seconds, which makes the average per page load-up time faster than one page a second. This figure is a lot faster than what users would achieve on a dial-up or a broadband Internet connection, which basically means that you won't be able to notice any difference in browsing speeds just by changing browsers when your connection is slow. Hence, at the end of the day there would be virtually no difference between performances of two browsers if your bandwidth is much lower than the fast speed at which your browser can process information.

Both versions of Netscape come with the AOL instant messenger, while MSN messenger is bundled with Internet Explorer. Mozilla allows you to connect to ChatZilla, a program for chatting on the IRC network. In Netscape, you can see your buddy list right on the screen in the side bar, so you don't have to launch the messenger, as in the case of MSN messenger. Both AOL and MSN messenger are at par in terms of functionality as they allow the exchange of files, voice chat, changing one's status, etc. The NeoPlanet browser features fully integrated instant messaging called Net Clubs, (you have to register and login to make it functional) which gives you access to bulletin boards, galleries and chat rooms.

Screening for security: The Internet is a resource of information, not to mention the vast range of services that you can avail from the Net for free. But for you to take full advantage of services such as online banking and shopping, you should choose a browser that supports high encryption (128 bit) for security of online transactions. And if you have children, you'd also